

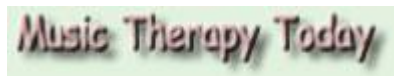
The Selection Of Music For Therapeutic Purposes

TALK TODAY INTERVIEW - SELECTING MUSIC FOR THERAPY

Question 3: Are there any specific methods undertaken in this therapy?

Answer 3 : The method involved in music therapy relates to the selection of music for a patient. The music therapist has to know the patient's likes and dislikes about sounds, music and instruments and accordingly prescribe either an assertive raga or relaxing raga depending on the patient's needs.

Complete interview is listed below & highlighted in sky blue color



Traditional healing systems and modern music therapy in India

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Abstract

This paper discusses about the integration of traditional Indian healing systems like Nadopasan, Ayurveda, Yoga, Raga Chikitsa and Nada Yoga into modern music therapy as a non medical modifier and protector of the impacts of disease and its treatment in clinical settings and the modified approaches and procedures that one can practice with reference to Indian context.

Key words

Nadopasana, Nada Yoga, Ayurveda, Raga Chikitsa, Yoga, Indian musical healing systems and Indian music therapy

Introduction

India has been known for its rich cultural heritage and traditions and many Indian traditional healing systems like Yoga and Ayurveda have been welcomed globally and have been given scientific endorsements for their therapeutic values. Indian traditional systems of health and healing also include various musical treatment approaches. A few healing traditions are also integrated in modern music therapy practice in India. All these approaches integrated with music not only prayer, but

also yoga and meditation and guide the participant in the art of living (Sundar, 2006).

Fire-walking, music and altered states of consciousness

Traditionally, these practices also integrate spirituality and address the imbalance between mind, body and spirit in improving health. There are some rituals and traditional practices which are en vogue even today reflecting strongly that music and sound are used to alter states of consciousness to reduce perception of pain. Fire-walking by thousands of Hindu devotees is an integral part of religious Hindu festivals. The devotees walk on red hot fire made of coal carrying kavadi (yoke used for carrying burden) by piercing silver or steel pins and skewers in many sizes all over the body through skin, backs, cheeks and tongue of the kavadi carrying devotees. These signify that the pins destroy all the desires and evils in man and purify the mind. The will, faith, concentration, piety and hope of the devotee alter their states of consciousness in such a way that no pain sensation is evident and strangely not a single drop of blood is seen oozing.

These rituals reflect the willingness of the devotees to suffer, with an appeal to god to for forgiveness of their evil needs and seeking blessing for good deeds. These religious rituals are preceded by many days of fasting, abstinence from sex and non vegetarian diet that they perceive could help suffering prior to performing these difficult vows. The devotees are brought to an altered state of consciousness in trance by the loud beats of drums and shouts with religious fervour "arohara" and the religious songs. The specific kind of rhythm based music and sounds contribute easy piercing of the skewers and pins into the body, which also prepare the devotees psychologically and physically to have a sense of control for performing these vows. It is this ongoing audio ambience that alters the state of consciousness and takes away the perception of pain.

Vedic traditions

Vedic traditions dating back roughly 5000 years ago had a great intuition about the power of sound and intonation. The Vedic chants and music which had more sound and rhythm, used as a source of healing and up liftment reflected the intuition that each intonation and inflection of voice could have beneficial or adverse effects. (Sumathy Sundar & Sairam, 2005) The Vedic chants were used by the people to please the presiding deities of different Vedic sacrifices to get benedictions of brilliance, power and wisdom to cure diseases. Phrases from Atharvana Veda (Whitney, 1971) indicated that accompanying the drinking of various things in a healing ceremony during Vedic times, Vedic hymns were also used against disease arising from hurtful changes of wind, bile or phlegm and for paying homage to lightning conceived as the cause of fever, headache and cough, to release the sufferer from head ache and cough. Present day music therapy practice involves use of archika, gathika and samika verses (Vedic verses with single, two and three notes respectively) to enhance focused attention and to improve concentration and to help get into meditative and relaxed states. These recitals called proto raga-s are used in special education settings for children with special needs in the process of mental developments, behavior and personality trait. With these *proto-ragas and rapid rhythms*, special children respond readily and more quickly than to medium-paced ragas. (Sairam, 2006)

Ayurveda

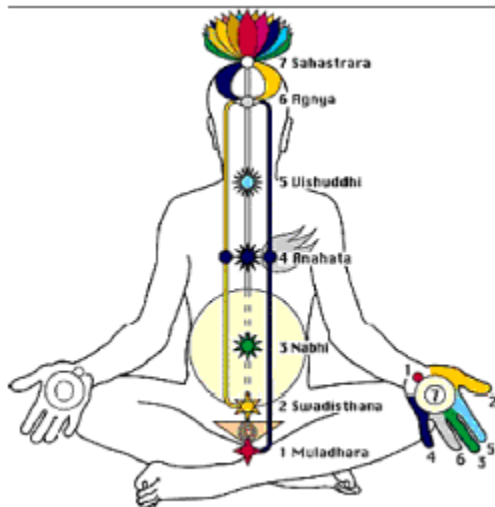
Ayurveda, the Vedic system of health care concerned with healthy living and not disease specific takes into account the patient's entire personality, body, mind and the spirit and guides the participants for a healthy living along with the therapeutic measures that relate to physical, mental, social and spiritual harmony.

It is based on a holistic approach rooted in the philosophy of Vedas and the Vedic culture. The ayurvedic principle assigns human body into 4 types Vata, Pitta, Kapha and Sannipada (the admixture of the said three) and that the four dhatu-s (humours) hold the body.

These four dhatu-s are assigned to the 22 sruti-s of the Indian music system according to the nature of these dhatu-s, the 3 dosha-s that represent an imbalance and three mala-s or dirt arising out of them. Raga-s have been classified in three groups namely Vata, Pitta and Kapha which notes the effects of raga-s on the human body. Also the swara-s are connected with the chakra-s (different energy centres in the body), cells and nerves and the physiological structure of the human body.

Pentatonic raga-s have been used for curing diseases, sickness and bad health, hexatonic raga-s to attain beauty, youth and charm and sampurna raga-s (raga-s with all the notes) were used for strength, wisdom, wealth, good harvest, prosperity and children. In contemporary times, Pandit Shasank Katti integrates these principles in his music therapy practice in clinical set ups.

FIGURE 1. Different Energy Centres in the human body



Yoga

Yoga is a Hindu discipline of training the consciousness for a state of perfect spiritual insight and tranquility, a union between the mind, body and the spirit by creating a balance in the body through developing both strength and flexibility through practicing asana-s. (Sumathy Sundar, 2004) by her study on the state anxiety of Head and Neck cancer patients indicated that Shavasana, (a yogic state of relaxation) combined with psychological counseling with a back ground music could be used to alleviate stress and bring down anxiety levels in radiation patients and brings about a state of relaxation during the periods of radiation treatment and help in completion of radiation treatment protocol.

Nada Yoga

Nada Yoga is a yoga of sound, a path of exploration of consciousness through sounds. Nada, the primordial sound forming the basis of music evolves in different stages of para, pashyanthi, madhyama and vaikhari from the different energy centres found in the human body and opening up of these seven chakra-s (energy centres) reflect their physical, psychological and physiological characteristics to reestablish our inner balance restoring health and form. The system involves deep listening to the body inner sounds and acoustics and music of the external worlds which are termed as Ahata and Anahata, integrate meditation techniques and certain hatha yoga practices conducive to sonic exploration. Most of the modern Indian music therapy approaches use Ahata music as a therapeutic and a prophylactic medium in clinical and educational settings.

Nadopasana

Nadopasana which is dedication to music is a path of musical yoga, part and parcel used in religious rites, rituals and sacrifices is considered as a medium of prayer to God, a path, a realization and a medium to seek salvation from the sins committed by oneself. Sundar (2006) by a case study of Carcinoma Hypopharynx indicated that the more cultural and traditional Indian music had a spiritual influence, which expressed one's devotional feelings and might bring comfort, hopes and peace of mind to the listeners and alleviate pain and anxiety. The study indicated that traditional healing method like nadopasana can be integrated in a cancer treatment as a supportive strategy in terms of modern music therapy and to find out the effects of music on cancer related pain and state anxiety. By using State-Trait Anxiety Inventory of Spielberger, the case study indicated how receptive music therapy in the form of nadopasana could be combined with comprehensive counseling and also if health information could be provided as a cognitive behavioural intervention to address psychological distress and situational anxiety, which are common problems with cancer patients in a hospital environment. Baseline data was collected from the patient using Spielberger's State-Trait Anxiety Inventory. Assessments were done for situational anxiety before, during and after the music and counseling interventions. Pre- and Post-test composite anxiety scores were compared, which indicated the efficacy of the treatment. Though the primary endpoint of the study was state anxiety, the unique experiences of listening to music, which could be explained only by the patient listening to music and the self report made by the patient when analysed reflected the spiritual dimensions of the music therapy sessions.

Raga Chikitsa

Raga Chikitsa, an extinct sanskrit treatise, as its name implies dealt with curative ragas and suggested specific ragas with specific therapeutic and mood enhancing characteristics suggested to be used in clinical settings are still more to be tested and validated. (Varadalakshmi, 1948), (Sairam, 2005). (Sairam, 2006) in his study on designing training methods for the mentally retarded (MR) children prescribed baseline rules for treating MR children as –

- (1) Beta music with rapid fire orchestral rhythms to activate participation and anger management, to gear up physiological activities and alertness in mind
- (2) Alpha music without rhythms to induce relaxation
- (3) repeated rhythmic experience to regulate the wavering emotions and to bring regularity by his experimental observations during music therapy sessions with mentally retarded children.

A modified version of the earlier documented raga chikitsa approach evolved by the author using karnatik ragas for music therapy intervention could be used in clinical set ups (Sumathy Sundar, 2006) catering to the individual needs of the clients, taking into consideration, factors like music preferences, the listening pattern, the socio-economic background and the level of exposure to classical music.

The raga-based approach broadly involves application of musical pieces with a specific emphasis on swara patterns, embellishments and appropriate rhythms. This approach being both melodic and rhythm depends on the intended music function and the therapeutic objective identified. Raga-s with swara-s having short or long intervals and different embellishments, could be chosen with the appropriate slow, medium or fast tempo, with or without technical virtuosity.

The applications would vary for different music functions identified a) audio analgesic, anxiolytic or sedative b) to be stimulating and energizing c) to be an active focus of attention etc.

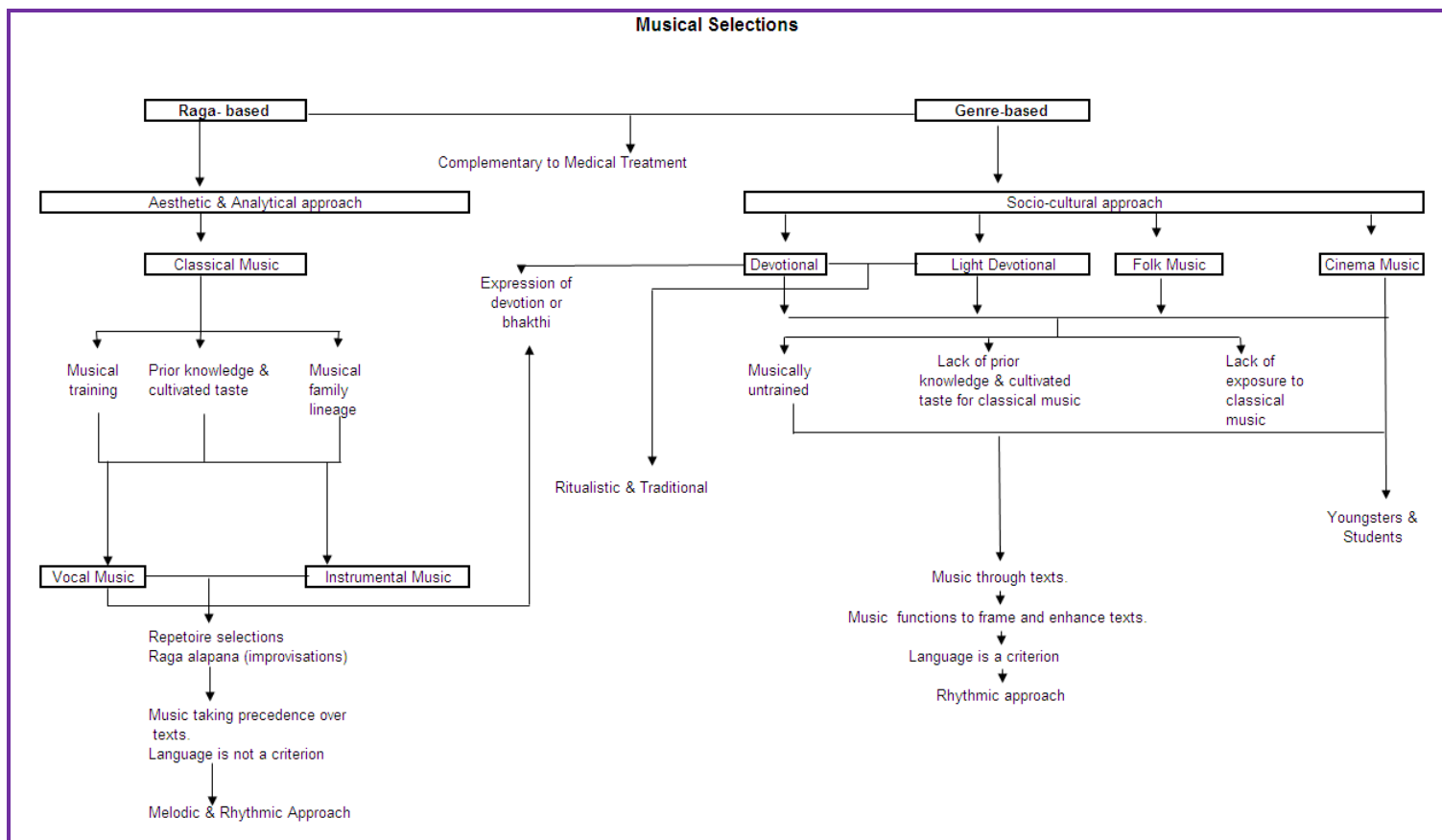
Raga with short intervalled and hitting notes

[Download Kadanakudukulam. Mp3](#) (2,8 MB)

Raga with stretching notes and embellishments used as audio analgesic

[Download Nilambari.Mp3](#) (5,3 MB)

FIGURE 2. Musical Selections



[Download figure2.xls \(36 kb\)](#)

Conclusion

Indian music therapy is an integration of ancient healing practices and musical traditions coupled with the recent modifications derived based on the modern day practice and the knowledge gained by current clinical studies undertaken. Indian music therapy is based on long empirical traditions not proven in the western sense of empiricism but it is unique and is cultural and throws open great scope for further prove and studies.

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